

Tool Shop

Bobby: A Web accessibility software that is compliant with existing accessibility guidelines. It enables visually impaired people to access and enjoy the same information available on the Internet that is available to the rest of the world.

Web site: <http://bobby.watchfire.com/bobby/html/en/index.jsp>



Focus: The Focus series of Braille displays come with keys that allow the user to navigate any software without reaching for the computer keyboard. They also have two audio inputs and one output for maximum usability. Two USB ports and programmable buttons further enhance its usefulness.

Web site:
http://www.freedomscientific.com/fs_products/displays_focusinfo.asp

IBM Home Page Reader 3.0: This software utilises IBM's ViaVoice text-to-speech synthesizer for reading out text, frames, images, text links, data input fields and other details on the Web. It is available in Brazilian Por-

tuguese, French, German, Italian, and Spanish.



Web site: <http://www-3.ibm.com/able/hpr.html>

JAWS 4.5: Job Access With Speech is designed to add speech output to applications. It uses configuration files to record speech parameters such as volume, rate, pitch and frame and macro definitions. The latest version supports Windows XP and Internet Explorer 6.



Web site: <http://www.freedomscientific.com>

[/fs_products/software_jaws.asp](http://www.freedomscientific.com/fs_products/software_jaws.asp)

PAC Mate BNS: A handheld designed exclusively for the visually impaired. Running JAWS for Windows, it provides the same applications that have been built for devices such as the Compaq iPaq. The PAC Mate BNS has Braille in and speech out capabilities and the PAC Mate BNS has a QWERTY-style keyboard with speech output.

Web site:
<http://www.freedomscientific.com>

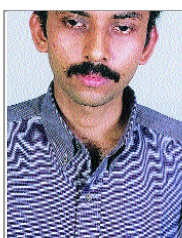
synthesiser offers support for seven languages—US English, British English, German, Italian, French and Latin Spanish.

The latest version incorporates features such as Smart Screen Technology to provide flexibility with menus and dialog

with Windows, which means that any enhancement in the OS, such as XP will be adapted to JAWS for Windows.

Filling the void

So are these tools restricted to a privileged few? Not at all. The makers of the technologies themselves are instrumental in spreading it to the intended audience. Most NGOs that set up computer training centres for the visually impaired consider only the costs of their sighted teachers—the equipment is sponsored by evangelist NGOs and developers of the technology. The Indian Association of the Visually Handicapped (IAVH), an association dedicated to informing, counselling and aiding the visually impaired, was built on grants from IDBI Bank, Microsoft and the HDFC bank. It has training centres in Mumbai, Pune, Nagpur, Hyderabad and Thiruvananthapuram. The Victoria



Hari Raghavan
CONSUMER MARKETING,

“Technology is what technology does, and it has made it possible for me to have a mainstream career”

boxes. A speech pad enables single-handed operation and voice configurations. It possesses enough intelligence to analyse the screen content and then speak, making it easier for the user to work unfamiliar applications. It also works in tandem

with Windows, which means that any enhancement in the OS, such as XP will be adapted to JAWS for Windows.